National Development Council (NDC) was supposed to give its final nod to the plan in its meeting scheduled on October 22, 2011 but as many working groups have not submitted their final reports to their respective divisions the process is getting delayed, it is expected to come to the NDC meeting by late 2012. As far as progress of the 12th Plan documentation is concerned, the NDC had approved the 'Approach Paper' on August 20, 2011 itself. The documents for 10th and 11th Plans too were finalised much later after the beginning of the respective Plan periods.

The Draft Approach Paper lays down the major targets of the Plan, the key challenges in meeting them, and the broad approach that must be followed to achieve the stated objectives which are summed-up as follows:

(i) Growth rate of 9 per cent is targeted for the Plan. However, in view of the uncertainties in the global economy and the challenges in the domestic economy, the Approach Paper indicates that it could be achieved only if some **difficult decisions** are taken.

(ii) It emphasizes the need to intensify efforts to have 4 per cent average growth in **agriculture** sector during the Plan period; with foodgrains growing at about 2 per cent per year and non-food grains (notably, horticulture, livestock, dairying, poultry and fisheries) growing at 5 to 6 per cent.

(iii) The higher growth in agriculture would not only provide broad based income benefits to the rural population but also help restrain **inflationary pressure**, which could arise if high levels of growth are attempted without corresponding growth in domestic food production capabilities.

(iv) It proposes that the major **flagship programmes** which were instrumental for promoting inclusiveness in the Eleventh Plan should continue in the Twelfth Plan – there is a need to focus on issues of implementation and governance to improve their effectiveness.

(v) The Plan indicates that the **energy** needs of rapid growth will pose a major challenge since these requirements have to be met in an environment where domestic energy prices are constrained and world energy prices are high and likely to rise further.